# What to do when you're not OK

There is a distinct possibility that you will find yourself being emotionally overwhelmed in the next few weeks and months. What follows are some suggestions to get you through that. Accept that this is something that may happen to you no matter how strong you normally are, and it will be easier to get through if you've planned for it.

## Be safe

Only carry on doing what you're doing if it's safe to do so, or if it would be unsafe to stop. If possible, take a break.

## Do something that calms you

Ideally, it's good to know what things calm you – this is more useful than trying to find something that calms you when you're upset. For example meditation is going to be more effective if you've practised it a few times, than if you're trying it for the first time during an anxiety attack. There are a lot of resources available; you don't need to be failing to cope to use them. Consider exploring some of the following (both of these are free but require an NHS email address):

- headspace.com/nhs – An app that gives guided meditation sessions. You can adjust the length of the meditation, and focus on particular goals.
- nhs.unmind.com/signup – This is a very useful suite of resources which offers tools to use in acute situations, and short courses to help prepare you. It also offers a method of tracking your mood and your mental wellness.

What calms you will be different for everyone. It might be meditation or yoga, writing in a diary or colouring, playing an instrument or reading. Choose something that you're doing regularly, and have any materials you require somewhere you can get to them. If nothing is to hand, consider the following:

- Control your breathing. Sit somewhere quiet, and slow your respiration rate down. Breathe in for a count of four, hold for a count of four, breathe out for a count of four, hold for a count of four. Repeat this entire cycle four times.
- Try to identify the following three things:
    - something you have complete control over (no matter how small it is);
    - something that you can accept (bear in mind that accepting something doesn't mean you're happy about it, it means you're going to concentrate your energy on something else);
    - something you can view as a positive challenge to take forward
- Find a journal and read one of the editorials. Make a conscious effort to understand each paragraph before you move on. Your goal is not to read the entire article, it is to understand completely the amount you've read.
- Take a pen and paper and write down exactly what you feel like right now. Be thorough, be honest. (You can always shred it when you're done.) If you don't feel you have a lot to say, focus on keeping your handwriting slow and tidy. If you have nothing at all to say, write out

something you know from memory. A poem you learned in school, a prayer, the WHO checklist.

## Speak to somebody

This is often the most difficult thing to do. Have a think now about who you would call, and how you would open the conversation. Consider 'buddying up' with someone, so that you both have a point of contact in a crisis. Look out for each other when on duty.

Consider using the Staff Wellbeing and Support Service (SWSS). There's a drop in lounge between Cybi ward and the Education Centre. You can book face to face sessions (or phone or Skype) by contacting 01248 384177 or BCU.SWSSWest@wales.nhs.uk

## Discuss it afterwards.

Talk about it afterwards with your colleagues. When we're open about things like this, we make it easier for others to discuss it, and that makes it easier for us all to cope.